Islam

Quick Facts: Islam

Name: Islam.

Founder: Muhammad (ca. 570–632 CE).

Titles: Prophet; Seal of the Prophets.

God: Monotheistic. The Arabic term for God is Allah.

Calendar: Year 1 = **622 CE**. Lunar based, with no adjustment for solar year.

Location: Started in Arabia; within a hundred years of Muhammad's death, Islam had conquered the area from the Atlantic coast of North Africa to India. Still largely located in that area and in Indonesia.

Primary Texts: Quran (the "Recitation"); Hadith.

Main Concepts: God has revealed himself often in the past, but the messages have been corrupted by those to whom the message was given. God gave his last and final message (the Quran) to Muhammad, his prophet. Salvation is achieved by submitting to God's will as revealed.

Hierarchy: Originally a caliph stood at the head of the Islamic community, though the Shia substituted that leadership with an imam. The caliphate ended in the early 1900s. No central authority exists.

Subgroups: Sunni (85 percent); Shia (Shiite) (15 percent).

Primary Obligations: The Five Pillars (confession of faith, prayer, fasting, almsgiving, pilgrimage).

Primary Festivals: Eid al-Fitr (fast-breaking feast at end of Ramadan); Eid al-Adha (feast at end of the hajj); the Mawlid (Muhammad's birthday).

Relation to Other Religions: Islam is a monotheistic reform movement of traditional Arabian religion, heavily colored by the Jewish Torah and to a lesser extent by Christian practices.

Places

Mecca: The pre-Islamic center of trade and religion for Arabs, which Muhammad reformed into a center of monotheism. Muslims who are able are expected to make a pilgrimage there at least once during their lifetime.

Medina: Originally called Yathrib, this settlement was later renamed Medina to honor Muhammad, who established his first Islamic government there (622 CE). The word Medina means simply "city," but it often appears with the epithet "of light" or "of the prophet."

Jerusalem: The third most holy city of Islam. The Dome of the Rock, a shrine built in the late 600s on the site of the Jewish temple, is particularl special. Muslims believe that it was here that Abraham offered Ishmael as a sacrifice and that Muhammad ascended to heaven.

Karbala: Revered site for Shia Muslims, where many of Ali's family,including Ali's son and s uccessor Hussein (Husayn) and Ali's grandson, and the next in line, were killed by a superior Umayyad army. (Shia Muslims take Ali, the son-in-law of Muhammad, to be the proper successor to Muhammad.)

Kaaba (lit., "cube"): A pre-Islamic, cube-shaped building (roughly forty feet high) in Mecca, rebuilt several times; believed by Muslims to have been built by Abraham, and before him, Adam. The Black Stone (possibly a meteorite) is imbedded in it. The Kaaba is the center of the Muslim pilgrimage and the place toward which one prays. Metaphorically speaking, it is said to be the "house of God."

Blue Mosque: A mosque built in the 1600s in the heart of Istanbul; represents a high point of Ottoman achievement.

Mosque (lit., "place of prostration"): The center of Muslim community and religious life. Its most distinctive architectural feature is the minaret (tower), from which the call to prayer is made.

Taj Mahal: A mausoleum in Agra, India, reflecting Muslim and Indian architecture. It is considered one of the most beautiful buildings in the world.

Leaders

Muhammad (ca. 570–632): Muslims believe that Muhammad was the last in a long series of prophets God sent to reveal his will. Muhammad experienced a twenty-two-year period of mystical encounters, during which the Quran's content was given.

Rightly Guided Caliphs: After the death of Muhammad, the Muslim community was led by four contemporaries of Muhammad (**Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman,** and **Ali**). These four had converted to Islam early. In succession, they led the community from 632 to 661, by which time much of the southeast Mediterranean was brought under Muslim control.

Ali: Cousin and son-in-law of Muhammad; considered by Shiite Muslims to have been the proper successor to Muhammad.

Major Empires

Umayyad (661–750): The first Muslim empire, lasting for ninety years. It arose after the death of the fourth rightly guided caliph. Its capital was Damascus. After defeat by the Abbasids, the Umayyads developed a significant Muslim culture in Spain.

Abbasid (750–1258): The five-hundred-year Muslim empire that overthrew the Umayyads. Its capital was Baghdad. Led by descendants of Muhammad's uncle al-Abbas, the new dynasty provided opportunities for non-Arabs in the Muslim community and came to reflect Persian and other non-Arab influences. Its golden age was in its first hundred years, after which it declined as states broke away and its leaders became the puppets of the palace guard. Initially it had the support of the Shiites.

Fatimid (909–1171): A Shiite dynasty in Egypt, claiming descent from Muhammad's daughter Fatima.

Mongol (1206–1481): The largest world empire prior to the Soviet Union. It rapidly expanded in the 1200s, overthrowing most nations from the Pacific to the Danube, including the Abbasid Empire.

Safavid (1501–1722): Centered in the regions of modern Iran and beyond; responsible for spreading Shia Islam more widely.

Mughal (1526–1857): The Muslim empire in India. Its name is the Persian form of the word Mongol, and the founders were descendants of Mongol and Turkish leaders.

Ottoman (1300–1922): The Turkish-based empire. It captured Constantinople in 1453. In the 1500s and 1600s it was the world's leading empire. It held the caliphate from 1515 to the early 1900s.

Major Groups

Sunni: The more traditional form, making up about 85 percent of Islam. Sunnis hold that political leadership of Islam properly fell to loyal companions of Muhammad (the "rightly-guided" caliphs) and their successors, not necessarily to Muhammad's relatives.

Shia/Shiite (lit., "party"): The largest minority, they maintain that valid religious and political leadership lies in the imam, a direct descendant of Muhammad through his daughter Fatima and her husband, Ali. Most groups of Shiites believe in twelve imams and are sometimes called the Twelvers.

They are a majority only in Iran and Iraq.

Ismaili: Also called Seveners; a Shiite group that disagrees with other Shiites about who should have become the seventh imam. They consider their leader, the present Aga Khan, to be the forty-ninth imam.

Kharijite (lit., "to go out, leave"): Early puritanical supporters of Ali who withdrew their loyalty from Ali. The Kharijites argued that the caliph need not be from the prophet's family (the Shiite position) or the prophet's tribe (the Sunni position). Any pious Muslim could lead.

Sufi: Mystical movement of Islam. The name comes from the plain woolen garment worn by members, in contrast to silks and expensive materials. One well-known group of Sufis is the Whirling Dervishes.

Wahhabi: A puritanical Sunni reform movement founded in 1746. Members opposed Sufism and Islamic rational theology and rejected as heresy previously accepted interpretations of Islam. Modern Saudi Arabia reflects their influence.

Zaidite: A Shiite movement that follows its own fifth imam, Zayd.

Symbols

Allahu akbar (lit., "God is great"; often translated as "God is greater" or "God

is greatest"): The audible symbol of Islam, pronounced in daily prayers but also on numerous other occasions, from the serious to the mundane.

Calligraphy: When Islam discouraged pictorial art, handwriting became an art, featuring words from the Quran. Scriptural calligraphy has for centuries served as the iconography of Islam. It is the closest one can come to depicting God.

The Color Green: The color most often identified with Islam. It was, according to some accounts, Muhammad's favorite color (other accounts say white). Muhammad wore green on different occasions and had a love for natural greenery. It is often the color of flags of Muslim nations. Also, garments to be worn in paradise are said to be green.

Crescent and Star: The most recognized symbol of Islam in the modern world, though not an official symbol. It was borrowed from Christian Constantinople by the conquering Ottomans.

Halal Certification: Identification of approved products, similar to the kosher labels used by Jews; commonly marked by an M enclosed in a circle with a crescent.

Hijab: The scarf or head covering worn by many Muslim women.

Minaret: The tower of a mosque from which the call to prayer is made five times each day. Some mosques have several minarets.

Niqab: The face veil worn by a minority of Muslim women, in addition to the hijab.

PBUH: An abbreviation often used by pious Muslims immediately after writing the word "Muhammad." Meaning is "Peace be upon him."

Prayer Beads/Rosary: In Islam, a string of prayer beads consists of ninet nine beads divided into three sections. They are used for reciting the ninet nine names of God.

Prayer Mat: Used by Muslims at prayer. A design is woven into the mat to point the worshiper in the direction of Mecca.

Prayer

Al-Fatihah (lit., "the opening"): The first surah (chapter) of the Quran is used as a common prayer by Muslims, being repeated at least seventeen times a day. Various English translations are available. The translation here follows Pickthall most closely but is modified to reflect contemporary English.

In the name of God,

the Beneficent, the Merciful. Praise be to God, Lord of the Worlds,

The Beneficent, the Merciful. Master of the Day of Judgment. You we worship;

You we ask for help. Show us the straight path,

The path of those whom You have favored;

Not the path of those who earn Your anger nor of those who go astray.

Major Texts

Quran/Koran (lit., "recitation"): The Islamic scripture, consisting of 114 chapters (surahs) of material that Muhammad "recited" during twenty-two years of religious experiences. Muslims understand this Arabic material to be the reliable revelation of God, replacing the corrupted texts that Jews and Christians had received (the Torah and the gospel). The Quran is about on fifth shorter than the Christian New Testament.

Hadith: The body of stories of what Muhammad did or said. This has become the second manual of authority for Muslims. Each story (hadith) has a chain of tradition attached, identifying the persons who transmitted thestory. That chain serves as the basis for a judgment about the reliability of the story, which can range from sound, good, or weak to fabricated. Various collections of hadiths appeared. About two centuries after Muhammad's death, a serious effort was made to determine which stories were trustworthy. Six collections won general approval.

The Revival of the Religious Sciences: A book by Al-Ghazali (d. 1111) that helped to renew Islam by emphasizing the necessity of inner virtue and religious experience in contrast to what the author judged to be legalism and intellectualism in the religious schools.

Thousand and One Nights: Also known as the Arabian Nights; a vast collection of secular and esoteric tales about life and fantasy in medieval Islam. Best known to English readers from tales of Aladdin and his magic lamp.

The Five Pillars

The following practices are common to all Muslims.

Creed/Profession of Faith (Shahadah) (lit., "bearing witness"): The confession: "I bear witness that there is no God but God, and Muhammad is the Prophet of God." The sincere recitation of this makes one a Muslim.

Prayer (Salat): Ritual prayer offered at five specific times each day: dawn, noon, afternoon, sunset, and nightfall. Worshipers pray wherever they are, though Muslims try to attend the mosque for the noon prayer on Friday. Muslims pray facing Mecca. Prayer is preceded by ritual washing and, if circumstances allow, a formal call to prayer.

Alms (Zakat): A tax on possessions, and various levels of taxes on agriculture produce. The tax is used for relief of the poor and religious purposes, such as education and building of mosques.

Fasting (Sawm): For the entire month of Ramadan, Muslims fast from dawn to dusk. A few exceptions are allowed—for the young, the elderly, the ill, pregnant or nursing women, and travelers. The fast involves abstinence from food, drink, and sexual relations.

Pilgrimage (Hajj): Once in one's lifetime, Muslims are expected to journey to Mecca, if they are able. The pilgrimage occurs over a six-day period in the last month of the year and involves a complex set of rituals around Mecca, recalling stories of Abraham and Ishmael. After completing the pilgrimage, the pilgrim bears the honorific title of hajji (for males) or hajjah (for women).

Duties and Ethics

Although Islam does not have a formal list of regulations, like the Ten Commandments in Judaism, Surah 17:22–39 provides one list of expected behavior. The following is a summary.

- Do not have any other god but God.

Show kindness to parents.

- Give to relatives what is their due. Give to the poor and the wayfarer. If you don't have money to give, speak a kind word.
- Don't waste your wealth.
- Don't be a miser.
- Don't kill your children. Provide for them.
- Don't commit adultery.
- Don't kill, except as allowed.
- Don't steal the property of orphans that is in your trust.
- Use honest weights and measures.
- Don't act arrogantly.

The Five Pillars: The main duties of a Muslim. (See "The Five Pillars" summary box.)

Shirk (lit., "making a partner"): The most dangerous offense in Islam is to associate other gods with the one God (polytheism) or to associate divine qualities to things that are not divine.

Rites and Rituals

Muslims have few rituals. Since Islam does not have priests, the rituals are carried out by the individual, not performed by the clergy.

Circumcision: Practices vary, but male children are circumcised. Although not commanded in the Quran, male circumcision copies the practice of Abraham. Female circumcision is also practiced in some Muslim cultures, though it does not have a strict religious basis, and the practice in these areas predates Islam.

Fasting: A daytime fast during the month of Ramadan. One of the Fiv Pillars.

Pilgrimage: The high point in the life of a Muslim is a pilgrimage to Mecca. The pilgrims clothe themselves in simple dress, visit particular sites associated with Abraham and Ishmael, and circle the Kaaba seven times. One of the Five Pillars.

Prayer: Prayer is ritualized in Islam, with five daily set times of prayer and with prescribed words and physical movements (prostration, bowing, and standing) performed in the direction of Mecca. Each cycle of movements is called a rakah. Careful ritual washing is required, as is a prayer mat. One of the Five Pillars.

Offices

Caliph (lit., "successor"): The leader of the Islamic community after Muhammad and after the Shiite schism of the Sunni community. Caliphs were not considered divinely inspired individuals, since Muhammad was viewed as the last of the prophets. Their role was bot religious and political.

Caliphate: The succession of caliphs, leaders of Sunni Islam. The institution was terminated by the Turkish Republic in 1924.

Imam (lit., "he who stands before" or "leader"): The leader of the Shiite community, comparable to the caliph of the Sunnis. In its more specific use, the term is applied to the leader who is a descendent of Ali and who has supernatural powers to interpret law.

Mahdi (lit., "guided one"): The ruler and religious leader who will appear just before the end of the world to restore justice and righteousness, associated with the return of Jesus (the masih or messiah). Mahdi and Jesus together will defeat the antichrist. In the majority tradition of Shia Islam, Mahdi is the hidden twelfth imam.

Ayatollah (lit., "sign of Allah"): A recently coined term for a high-ranking religious scholar in the Shiite tradition in Iran.

Dervish (lit., "poor"): An initiate into the ascetic lifestyle of the Sufi brotherhood. The term is derived from the Persian word darwish, which is a translation of the Arabic fakir.

Muezzin (lit., "crier"): One who formally calls Muslims to prayer five times daily from the minaret.

Festivals/Sacred Time

The following festivals are listed in chronological order. Islam uses a lunar calendar.

New Year's Day: A celebration of the flight (hijra) of Muhammad from Mecca to Medina in 622 CE. It marks the beginning of the Muslim calendar.

Muhammad's Birthday (Mawlid): The celebration of Muhammad's birthday.

Night Journey (Miraj): A celebration of Muhammad's journey (ascension) to heaven from Jerusalem.

Night of Power: The celebration of the beginning of the revelatory experiences of Muhammad that came to compose the Quran.

Eid al-Fitr (lit., "Feast of Fast Breaking" or "Small Feast"): This event marks the end of the month-long fast of Ramadan.

Eid al-Adha (lit., "Feast of the Sacrifice" or "Great Feast"): This event marks the end of the pilgrimage to Mecca. Muslims offer a sacrifice on this occasion, commemorating Abraham' "sacrifice" of Ishmael.

Friday Noon Prayer: Although Muslims do not have a weekly holy day, such as the Jewish Sabbath or the Christian Sunday, many Muslims attend Friday noon prayers in the mosque.

Terminology

Dar al-Islam (lit., "the abode of Islam"): Those lands in which Islam is dominant and Muslim law prevails. See "ummah."

Dhimmis (lit., "protected persons"): In Islamic countries, "People of the Book" (traditionally understood to be Jews and Christians) are permitted to practice their religion as dhimmis, after paying a special tax.

Fatwa: A legal opinion by a qualified jurist, clarifying a disputed point of law. In practice, a fatwa is treated as having the force of law.

Islam (see SLM; lit., "surrender"): The term for the religion of Muslims.

Jihad (lit., "struggle"): The personal struggle of a Muslim in the way of piety, or the militant struggle to defend and extend Islam. The latter is commonly called "Holy War."

Muslim (see SLM; lit., "one who surrenders"): The term for an adherent of Islam.

SLM: The letters of the consonantal root on which the words Islam andMuslim are built. Its primary meaning for Muslims is "surrender." **Ummah**: The people; the community. Used by Muslims to identify the community of Islam, ideally undivided, although from the earliest days the ummah has been split.